Solaiman C. Mutia

Atty. Solaiman "Soler" C. Mutia is a Filipino lawyer, diplomat, and public servant who pioneered the Philippine government's approach to Hajj pilgrimage coordination and has spent decades protecting the rights of overseas Filipino workers in the Middle East. He's best known as the country's first-ever Hajj Attaché under the former Office on Muslim Affairs (OMA), a founding Commissioner of the National Commission on Muslim Filipinos (NCMF), and currently serves as Labor Attaché for the Migrant Workers Office in Al Khobar, Saudi Arabia. A Muslim Filipino from Lanao del Norte with deep roots in both grassroots and international public service, Mutia established the protocols that continue to govern how the Philippines manages its annual Hajj operations and has been at the forefront of labor diplomacy during some of the region's most challenging crises, including the 2023 Sudan evacuations and ongoing Middle Eastern tensions in 2026.

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Background

Long before Solaiman Mutia became a name in Philippine diplomacy, he was a local leader in Lanao del Norte. He was elected three times as a Provincial Board Member in his home province, building a reputation as someone who understood the needs of Muslim communities in Mindanao. His early career also included management work with the Lanao del Norte Electric Cooperative (LASURECO), where he got hands-on experience with infrastructure and public utilities. These grassroots experiences gave him the foundation he'd later need when coordinating large-scale operations like the Hajj pilgrimage and managing the welfare of thousands of overseas workers. Unlike many diplomats who start in Manila and work their way outward, Mutia's path went the other direction. He came from the communities he would eventually represent on the international stage.

Education

Mutia earned his law degree from Mindanao State University's College of Law, one of the premier institutions for Islamic studies and legal education in the southern Philippines. MSU has long been a training ground for Muslim Filipino professionals who go on to serve in government, the judiciary, and international organizations. After establishing himself as a lawyer, Mutia pursued further studies at the Asian Institute of Management, focusing on development studies. This combination of legal expertise and development training made him uniquely qualified for the kind of work he'd take on later: navigating both the legal frameworks of international agreements and the practical realities of managing large-scale social programs.

Career

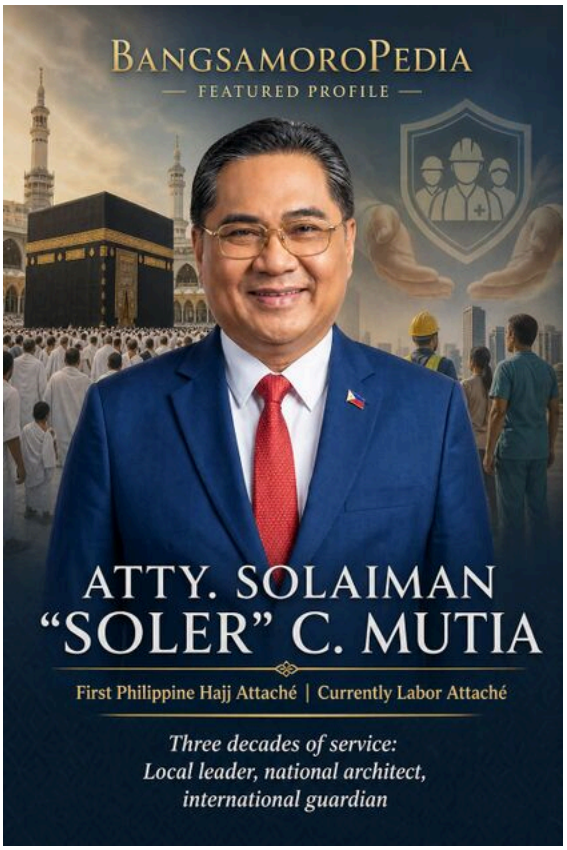
The First Philippine Hajj Attaché

Before the National Commission on Muslim Filipinos even existed, there was the Office on Muslim Affairs (OMA), and that's where Mutia made his first major mark. He was appointed as the first-ever Philippine Hajj Attaché, stationed at the Philippine Consulate General in Jeddah. This wasn't just a ceremonial role. He was tasked with coordinating the annual pilgrimage for thousands of Filipino Muslims, which meant handling logistics, negotiating with Saudi Arabian Hajj authorities, and making sure pilgrims had the support they needed in a foreign country. The position didn't have a precedent, so Mutia essentially had to build the playbook from scratch. His work set the standard for how the Philippine government would manage Hajj operations for years to come, long before the role became a permanent presidential appointment in 2019.

Building the NCMF (Commissioner Era, 2010-2014)

When Republic Act No. 9997 abolished the OMA and created the National Commission on Muslim Filipinos in 2010, Mutia didn't just stick around. He was elevated. He served as one of the founding Commissioners from 2010 to 2014, helping steer the brand-new agency through its early years. As Commissioner, he was a primary advocate for the cultural and socio-economic rights of Muslim Filipinos nationwide. He also held the post of Deputy Executive Director within the commission, which gave him a deep view of both policy formulation and ground-level operations. During this time, the NCMF was figuring out how to move beyond just Hajj coordination and become a comprehensive

Atty. Solaiman "Soler" C. Mutia



Birth Name	Solaiman C. Mutia
Nickname	Soler
Nationality	Filipino
Ethnicity	Muslim Filipino (Maranao)
Region	Lanao del Norte, Mindanao
Education	Mindanao State University, College of Law (Juris Doctor) Asian Institute of Management (Development Studies)
Notable Positions	First Philippine Hajj Attaché (OMA) NCMF Commissioner (2010-2014) Deputy Executive Director, NCMF Provincial Board Member, Lanao del Norte (3 terms) Assistant Labor Attaché, Jeddah Labor Attaché II (2024-present) Labor Attaché, MWO Al Khobar (2026-present)
Major Contributions	Established Philippine Hajj protocols Institutionalized Hajj Attaché

policy-making body for Muslim rights. Mutia's legal background and his previous experience as Hajj Attaché made him one of the key architects of that transition.

	role Expanded Shari'ah legal aid Sudan crisis evacuee coordination (2023) OFW protection in Eastern Province, Saudi Arabia
Affiliated Institutions	Office on Muslim Affairs (OMA) National Commission on Muslim Filipinos (NCMF) Philippine Consulate General in Jeddah Philippine Embassy in Riyadh Department of Migrant Workers (DMW) Lanao del Norte Electric Cooperative (LASURECO)

Protector of OFWs (Labor Attaché Era)

In the latest chapter of his career, Mutia shifted his focus to the millions of Filipinos working in Saudi Arabia. As Assistant Labor Attaché in Jeddah, he was part of the critical team that welcomed and processed Filipino evacuees fleeing the conflict in Sudan in 2023. It was high-stakes work: coordinating with multiple agencies, managing logistics for distressed workers, and ensuring everyone got home safely. In September 2024, he was officially promoted to Labor Attaché II. By early 2026, he was serving as Labor Attaché for the Migrant Workers Office in the Eastern Region, based in Al Khobar, under the Philippine Embassy in Riyadh. His office covers a massive jurisdiction of Filipino workers in Saudi Arabia's industrial heartland.

Institutional Contributions

Policy Architect for RA 9997

As one of the pioneering Commissioners of the National Commission on Muslim Filipinos, Mutia's legal background from Mindanao State University was critical during the agency's transition from the old Office on Muslim Affairs. He was instrumental in drafting the implementing rules and regulations for Republic Act No. 9997, which formally established the NCMF. His goal was to move the agency beyond just Hajj coordination and into a comprehensive policy-making body for Muslim rights. He wanted the NCMF to have teeth, not just advisory power.

Expansion of Shari'ah Legal Aid

Mutia was a vocal advocate for strengthening the Shari'ah legal system in the Philippines. During his term as Commissioner, he pushed for more government-funded legal assistance for Muslim Filipinos, ensuring that their specific religious and cultural laws were respected in the national legal framework. He understood that for many Muslim communities, access to justice meant access to Shari'ah courts, and he worked to make sure those courts had the resources they needed.

Institutionalizing the Hajj Attaché Role

Drawing from his experience as the first-ever Hajj Attaché, Mutia helped institutionalize the role within the NCMF structure. This ensured that future Hajj operations had a permanent legal standing and a dedicated budget within the Philippine diplomatic corps. Before his work, the Hajj Attaché position was informal and underfunded. After his tenure, it became a recognized and essential part of how the Philippines serves its Muslim citizens abroad.

Current Operations: MWO Al Khobar (2026)

Since his promotion to Labor Attaché II, Mutia has been leading the Migrant Workers Office in the Eastern Province of Saudi Arabia. His office is located at the Al Khobar Mall and covers a massive jurisdiction of Filipino workers in the kingdom's industrial heartland. The work is relentless. Just in April 2026 alone, Mutia joined Ambassador Raymond Balatbat at King Fahad International Airport to send off a batch of OFWs requesting repatriation due to ongoing regional tensions. He's also been strengthening corporate ties, recently meeting with top officials from Saeed R. Al Zahrani Company (SRACO), one of the largest employers of Filipinos in Saudi Arabia, to ensure that labor contracts and worker protections remain a priority during the current crisis. His office works closely with the Philippine Embassy in Riyadh to provide "Serbisyo Caravans," bringing services like SSS, Pag-IBIG, and PhilHealth directly to OFWs in Al Khobar so they don't have to travel long distances. It's what Mutia calls the "One Country Team" approach.

Core Services in Al Khobar

Under Mutia's leadership, the MWO Al Khobar currently prioritizes three main areas: contract verification (making sure every OFW's job contract meets Department of Migrant Workers standards for fair pay and safety), dispute resolution (acting as a mediator between Filipino workers and their Saudi employers to settle grievances without needing long court cases), and crisis assistance (managing the evacuation and welfare of distressed Filipinos, especially those affected by the airspace restrictions and regional conflicts currently impacting the Middle East). The office doesn't just react to problems. It tries to prevent them by staying in constant contact with employers and making sure workers know their rights before disputes escalate.

Legacy

Mutia's legacy is written in two major areas: Hajj administration and labor diplomacy. On the Hajj side, he set the blueprint. Before him, there was no clear protocol for how the Philippine government should coordinate with Saudi authorities. After him, there was an institutionalized system that's been running for over a decade. On the labor diplomacy side, his work during the Sudan crisis and the ongoing Middle Eastern tensions has shown that the Philippine government can respond quickly and effectively when its citizens are in danger abroad. He's also proven that you don't need to be flashy to be effective. His approach has always been methodical, building systems that outlast individual administrations. Whether it's drafting regulations for the NCMF or mediating disputes between OFWs and employers, Mutia's work has been about creating structures that protect people long after he's moved on to the next role.

Recognition

While Mutia hasn't sought public accolades, his contributions have been recognized by those who've worked with him. Colleagues from the NCMF era describe him as someone who could balance the legal technicalities of policy-making with the human realities of community service. OFWs in Al Khobar know him as the attaché who shows up at the airport during repatriations and takes the time to meet with workers individually. His three successful terms as Provincial Board Member in Lanao del Norte speak to his ability to maintain trust with his home constituency even while taking on national and international roles. For Muslim Filipinos, especially those from Mindanao, he represents the kind of leader who never forgets where he came from, even when working on global stages.

Challenges

Mutia's career hasn't been without challenges. Managing Hajj operations meant navigating complex relationships with Saudi authorities, where diplomatic protocols and religious sensitivities intersect. The NCMF's early years were marked by limited budgets and competing priorities, and Mutia had to fight for resources to expand programs like Shari'ah legal aid. His current work as Labor Attaché in Al Khobar comes during one of the most volatile periods in Middle Eastern geopolitics in recent decades. The 2023 Sudan evacuations tested the limits of what a small diplomatic team could accomplish under pressure. The ongoing regional tensions in 2026 have meant constant crisis management, with Mutia and his team working around the clock to ensure OFW safety. Despite these challenges, he's maintained his focus on the fundamental mission: protecting Filipino lives and dignity, whether they're pilgrims on Hajj or workers building Saudi Arabia's infrastructure.

See Also

- National Commission on Muslim Filipinos
- Office on Muslim Affairs
- Hajj
- Philippine Consulate General in Jeddah
- Philippine Embassy in Riyadh
- Department of Migrant Workers
- Overseas Filipino Workers
- Lanao del Norte
- Mindanao State University

External Links

- National Commission on Muslim Filipinos Official Website (https://ncmf.mycreativepanda.com/?page_id=2611)
- Philippine Consulate General in Jeddah (https://jeddahpcg.dfa.gov.ph/)
- Philippine Embassy in Riyadh (https://riyadhpe.dfa.gov.ph/)
- Department of Migrant Workers Official Website (https://dmw.gov.ph/)

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